

Pass Your Texas State Board Practical Exam The First Time.

Your complete supply checklist, exam-day tips, mindset prep, and printable labels — all in one place.

By Teresa | Board Ready Beauty | boardreadybeauty.com

119

Total Points

70%

To Pass (84 pts)

3h 31m

Exam Duration

9

Graded Sections

How the Practical Exam Is Scored

The practical exam has two types of scored criteria in each section:

Procedure Criteria — steps must be completed **in the exact order listed**. Skip a step or do it out of order and you lose that point.

Safety & Sanitation Criteria — evaluated throughout every section. These include: properly disposing of waste, keeping your kit sanitary, maintaining draping, avoiding cross contamination, and replacing contaminated items.

At the end of each section, **step back and raise your hand** to signal completion. Evaluators observe silently — they cannot coach you or repeat instructions.

★ Teresa's Tip

Sanitation points are worth just as much as technique points — and students lose them constantly by forgetting to cap bottles or dispose of used materials. Treat every safety step like it's worth your license.

The 9 Exam Sections at a Glance

Pre-Examination Set Up & Disinfection	10 min	4 safety pts	Unpack kit, disinfect surfaces
Monomer & Polymer Over Tip	32 min	8 procedure + 6 safety	Apply nail tip + acrylic overlay

Blood Exposure Incident	12 min	5 procedure + 6 safety	Gloves, clean, bandage, dispose, sanitize
Facial	17 min	12 procedure + 6 safety	Full facial with massage manipulations
Waxing	14 min	8 procedure + 6 safety	Wax removal service
Haircut	42 min	9 procedure + 6 safety	Cut min. 1 inch throughout entire head
Permanent Wave	22 min	6 procedure + 6 safety	Wrap min. 6 rods, saturate, test curl
Blow Dry & Thermal Curling	22 min	6 procedure + 6 safety	Blow dry + on-base and off-base curls
Hydroxide Relaxer Retouch	10 min	1 procedure + 6 safety	Retouch application to new growth only
End of Examination Disinfection	10 min	3 safety pts	Dispose, disinfect, remove all supplies

Your Exam Day Supply Checklist

Pack everything the night before. Arrive with your kit organized and ready. See the Labeling Rules page — some items **MUST** be labeled, others must **NOT**. Getting this wrong costs points.

Required for All Sections — General Supplies

- **Mannequin head (with sufficient hair)**
Enough hair for haircut, perm, blow dry, and relaxer sections
- **Mannequin clamp / table mount**
Secures mannequin to your workstation
- **Mannequin hand/finger (prepped with tips)**
Represents the natural nail — trainer hands are NOT permitted
- **Disinfectant spray or wipes**
For pre-exam setup and end-of-exam disinfection of work surfaces — **MUST BE LABELED**
- **Disinfectant jar / wet sanitizer**
For implements — must remain filled throughout exam — **MUST BE LABELED**
- **Disposable gloves (multiple pairs)**
Required for Blood Exposure Incident; recommended throughout
- **Hand sanitizer**
Sanitize/clean hands before each section — **MUST BE LABELED**
- **Trash bags / waste disposal container**
Proper waste disposal is scored in every section — **MUST BE LABELED**
- **Towels / draping cape**
Must maintain draping throughout applicable services
- **Spray bottle with water**
For wetting hair — **MUST BE LABELED**
- **Comb set (rattail, wide-tooth, styling)**
Used across haircut, perm, blow dry, relaxer — **do NOT label**
- **Duckbill / sectioning clips**
Sectioning — **do NOT label**
- **30" x 30" kit bag**
MUST be labeled: 'Pre-sanitized, Clean or Disinfected'

Section 2 — Monomer & Polymer Over Tip (32 min)

- **Nail tips (assorted sizes)**
Select and adhere tip — **do NOT label**
- **Nail adhesive / glue**
To adhere the nail tip — **MUST BE LABELED**

■ **Nail tip cutter / trimmer**
Trim tip to correct length — do NOT label

■ **Nail file / buffer**
Blend tip and finish surface — do NOT label

■ **Odorless monomer (liquid)**
ONLY manufacturer-labeled 'odorless' bottles accepted — MUST HAVE MANUFACTURER LABEL

■ **Low odor primer**
Same rule — manufacturer label only

■ **Polymer powder**
Keep capped when not in use — MUST BE LABELED

■ **Acrylic brush**
For applying overlay — do NOT label

■ **Nail dehydrator / cleanser**
MUST BE LABELED

■ **Dappen dish**
For monomer — do NOT label

■ **Orangewood stick / cuticle pusher**
Nail prep — do NOT label

■ **Cuticle oil**
Optional finishing — MUST BE LABELED if brought

■ **Manicure table mat / pad**
Setting up the manicure table is scored Step 1 — do NOT label

★ **Scored Order**

Steps must be done in order: (1) Set up manicure table, (2) Sanitize hands, (3) Prepare nail, (4) Select & adhere tip, (5) Trim tip, (6) Blend tip, (7) Apply monomer & polymer, (8) Finish surface. Out of order = lost points.

Section 3 — Blood Exposure Incident (12 min)

■ **Blood exposure kit / first aid kit**
Bring as a labeled kit — MUST BE LABELED as a unit

■ **Disposable gloves**
Must put on gloves FIRST — Step 1, scored — do NOT label

■ **Antiseptic / soothing lotion**
To clean the simulated cut — MUST BE LABELED

■ **Bandages / adhesive bandage**
To bandage the simulated cut — do NOT label

■ **Biohazard bag / disposal container**
Safe disposal of blood-exposed materials

- **Paper towels**
Clean up and disposal — do NOT label

★ **Most Missed Step**

Gloves go on FIRST before touching anything. No gloves first = lost point, no exceptions.

Section 4 — Facial (17 min)

- **Eye makeup remover**
Step 3 — MUST BE LABELED
- **Facial cleanser / cleansing product**
Step 4 — MUST BE LABELED
- **Sponges or cotton pads (several)**
Removal — dispose immediately — do NOT label
- **Massage product**
Step 6 — MUST BE LABELED
- **Astringent, freshener, or toner**
Step 11 — MUST BE LABELED
- **Moisturizer**
Step 12, final step — MUST BE LABELED
- **Protective cream**
MUST BE LABELED if brought
- **Facial spatulas (disposable)**
Sanitary product application — do NOT label
- **Headband / hair clip for mannequin**
Prepare mannequin is a scored step — do NOT label
- **Towels / draping**
Must maintain draping throughout

★ **All 3 Massage Types**

Effleurage (gliding), Petrissage (kneading), and Tapotement (tapping) — each is a separate scored point. Do not skip any.

Section 5 — Waxing (14 min)

- **Simulated soft wax product**
e.g., petroleum jelly or honey — MUST BE LABELED as such

- **Wax warmer / heater**
Pre-heat before exam — do NOT label

- **Wax applicator sticks (many)**
Double-dipping is a violation — bring plenty — do NOT label

- **Muslin strips (if soft wax)**
Pre-cut and ready — do NOT label

- **Pre-wax skin prep / cleanser**
Cleansing product — MUST BE LABELED

- **Post-wax soothing lotion**
Antiseptic/soothing lotion — MUST BE LABELED

- **Protective cream**
MUST BE LABELED

- **Gloves**
Recommended for chemical/wax service — do NOT label

★ No Double-Dipping

Used applicators must be disposed of immediately. Containers stay closed when not in use.
Both are scored safety points.

Section 6 — Haircut (42 min)

- **Haircutting shears (sharp)**
Must cut a minimum of 1 inch throughout the entire head — do NOT label

- **Thinning shears (optional)**
Finishing only — do NOT label

- **Razor with guard (optional)**
do NOT label

- **Cutting comb**
do NOT label

- **Wide-tooth comb**
do NOT label

- **Sectioning clips (6–8)**
do NOT label

- **Spray bottle with water**
MUST BE LABELED

- **Cape / draping**
Must maintain draping — do NOT label

- **Neck strip**
do NOT label

- **Hand broom or brush for workstation**
Removing hair from work area is scored Step 8 — do NOT label

- **NOTE: Broom and dustpan**
PROVIDED by the exam venue — do not bring your own

★ **Don't Forget the Floor**

Removing hair from work area (Step 8) AND sweeping floor (Step 9) are both separately scored. Don't skip the floor.

Section 7 — Permanent Wave (22 min)

- **Perm rods — minimum 6**
Center back section — do NOT label
- **End papers / end wraps**
Required for proper wrapping — do NOT label
- **Simulated perm solution**
e.g., water — MUST BE LABELED as simulated perm product
- **Cotton coil / barrier strips**
Protective cotton — do NOT label
- **Plastic wrap or processing cap**
Cover rods during processing — do NOT label
- **Application brush or bottle**
Tint brush/bowl/bottle — do NOT label
- **Gloves**
Chemical service — do NOT label
- **Towels / cape**
Draping must be maintained — do NOT label
- **Neutralizer (available)**
Examiner will instruct test curl — do NOT label

★ **Test Curl**

Unwrap one rod, check the 'S' wave curl formation, and rewrap. Band placement is also scored — bands must be in the correct position on the rod.

Section 8 — Blow Dry & Thermal Curling (22 min)

- **Blow dryer**
do NOT label
- **Round brush**
do NOT label

■ **Electric curling iron**
On-base and off-base curls both required — do NOT label

■ **Sectioning clips**
do NOT label

■ **Spray bottle with water**
Mannequin hair must be wet to start — MUST BE LABELED

■ **Tail comb / pintail comb**
do NOT label

★ **On-Base vs.
Off-Base**

Curl #1 = on-base (full volume lift). Curl #2 = off-base (flat, close to head). Both are individually scored — the evaluator is watching for intentional placement.

Section 9 — Hydroxide Relaxer Retouch (10 min)

■ **Simulated chemical service product**
e.g., gel or cholesterol — MUST BE LABELED as simulated chemical service product

■ **Protective cream / base cream**
Apply to previously relaxed hair before chemical — MUST BE LABELED

■ **Application brush / tint brush**
do NOT label

■ **Gloves (heavy-duty preferred)**
Chemical service — do NOT label

■ **Sectioning clips**
4-quadrant sectioning — do NOT label

■ **Plastic bowl**
For product — do NOT label

■ **Cape / draping**
Must maintain draping — do NOT label

■ **Trash bag(s)**
Dispose of used applicators — MUST BE LABELED

★ **Retouch = New
Growth Only**

Apply to new growth only. Overlap onto previously relaxed hair is a professional error. You have only 10 minutes — work quickly and with purpose.

Section 10 — End of Examination Disinfection (10 min)

■ **Trash bags**
Dispose of ALL used materials — scored Step 1 — MUST BE LABELED

■ **Disinfectant spray/wipes**
Disinfect AND clean work area — both parts are scored Step 2 — MUST BE LABELED



Bag / case for all personal supplies

Remove ALL supplies, materials, and personal belongings — scored Step 3

★ Leave Nothing Behind

Leaving anything on the workstation means losing Step 3 points. Items left behind will be discarded by the venue. Do a full sweep.

Exam Day Tips from Teresa

1 Pack the night before.

Lay everything out. Check it against this list. Bag it organized. Morning-of rushing causes forgotten items and forgotten points.

2 Label your supplies — correctly.

Required items must be labeled in English. No numbers on labels. No task steps written on containers. Your printable labels are in the bonus section of this guide. Tape them on the night before.

3 Know the order — don't improvise.

Procedure criteria **MUST** be performed in the exact order listed. Additional or altered steps are not rated and can break your flow.

4 Sanitation is points — every section.

Safety criteria apply in every single section. Cap your bottles. Dispose of waste immediately. Replace contaminated items. Never double-dip.

5 Raise your hand at the end of each section.

Step back and raise your hand to signal completion. If you forget, the evaluator may not record your finish.

6 You cannot ask the evaluator for help.

Evaluators can only answer general questions — they cannot coach you, re-read instructions, or redirect you. Know your steps cold before you arrive.

7 No cheat sheets. No task lists on containers.

Writing task steps on bottles or bags = loss of ALL Procedure Criteria points for the entire exam. Identifying a bag by service (e.g. 'facial bag') is allowed.

8 Don't watch other candidates.

Keep your eyes on your own workstation. Observing others is a violation of exam rules.

9 Aerosol cans are not allowed.

Use pump sprays, non-aerosol products, and spray bottles only. Aerosols will be turned away.

10 Arrive early. Set up with purpose.

Find your station and unpack during the 10-minute setup window. Setup is scored — disinfecting your work surface is Step 1 of the entire exam.

11 Closed-toe shoes only.

You will not be permitted into the exam room without them. No exceptions.

Want to walk in even more prepared? **Join Teresa's 3-Hour Board Ready Beauty Practical Exam Prep Class — \$150** boardreadybeauty.com

Prepare Your Mind & Body

Your hands carry the skills. Your mindset carries you through. These tips are simple, free, and within reach of any student — and they can make the difference between a shaky morning and a confident one.

The Night Before the Exam

■ **Stop studying by 8 PM.**

At this point, cramming adds anxiety, not knowledge. Everything you need is already in your hands. Trust the hours you put in. Your brain consolidates memory while you sleep — let it do its job.

• **Pack your kit completely — then close it.**

Use this checklist. Pack it. Check it off. Zip it up. Once it's done, it's done. Obsessing over it at midnight won't help. Done is done.

• **Lay out your outfit the night before.**

Closed-toe shoes, comfortable clothes you can move in. One less decision in the morning means one less thing to stress about. Keep it simple.

■ **Eat a real dinner.**

■ Your brain needs fuel. A balanced meal — protein, carbs, something green — will serve you better than skipping dinner or eating junk. Don't try anything new that might upset your stomach.

• **Limit screens after 9 PM.**

Phone scrolling keeps your brain wired. Put it down an hour before bed. Read something light, take a bath, stretch. Tell your nervous system it's safe to rest.

• **Get in bed 30 minutes earlier than usual.**

Even if you don't fall asleep right away, resting quietly is still recovery. Your goal is 7–8 hours. A tired brain makes simple mistakes on steps you know cold.

Write down one thing you're proud of.

■ Seriously. Just one. Maybe it's that you showed up every day. Maybe it's that you finally nailed the perm rod tension. Write it down. Read it before you sleep. You've earned this exam.

Morning of the Exam

• **Eat breakfast — something real.**

Eggs, oatmeal, toast, a banana. Blood sugar crashes during a 3.5-hour exam are real. Bring a small snack in your car if you want it after, but fuel up before you walk in.

• **Give yourself extra travel time.**

Plan to arrive 20–30 minutes early. Traffic, parking, and sign-in take longer than you think. Rushing in stressed sets a shaky tone for everything that follows.

- **Do a 5-minute breathing reset in your car.**

Before you get out: breathe in for 4 counts, hold for 4, out for 6. Repeat 5 times. This activates your parasympathetic nervous system — it physically calms your heart rate and clears your head. It takes 5 minutes and it works.

- **Drink water. Bring a bottle for your car.**

Dehydration causes brain fog. You won't be able to bring it into the exam room, so hydrate well before you walk in. Even mild dehydration affects focus and fine motor control.

- **Wear layers if you run cold or hot.**

Exam rooms can be cold. You cannot leave once you're signed in. Dress for a range.

Mindset Adjustments That Actually Work

- 1 **You already know how to do this.**

You have spent 1,000+ hours learning these skills. The exam does not add new difficulty — it just asks you to demonstrate what you already know, in order, with care. You are not going in to learn something new. You are going in to show what you already have.

- 2 **Nerves are not the enemy.**

A little adrenaline sharpens your focus. The goal is not to feel nothing — the goal is to feel ready. Nerves mean you care. Channel it: take a breath, set your station, begin. The doing is always calmer than the waiting.

- 3 **One section at a time. One step at a time.**

Don't think about the haircut while you're doing the facial. Don't think about the relaxer while you're wrapping a perm rod. Stay in the section you are in. This exam is a series of small tasks, not one enormous one. Do the next right step.

- 4 **If you lose your place — pause, reset, continue.**

If you blank on a step, take a breath. Don't spiral. Don't rush to make up for it. Rushing causes more mistakes than the original pause ever would. A calm, steady pace scores more points than a frantic one.

- 5 **You are not competing with anyone else in that room.**

Your score has nothing to do with theirs. Eyes on your own station. Your only job is to execute your sections correctly. That's it.

- 6 **Passing this exam means something real.**

It means you get to do the work you trained for. It means your license. It means your career. Keep that in view when a step feels hard. You didn't put in all those hours to give up in the room. Finish strong.

- 7 **After you raise your hand at the end — you're done with that section.**

Let it go. Don't replay it. Move to the next one with a clean slate. Ruminating on a section you've already finished is the fastest way to lose points in the next one.

"You've done the work. Now go show them." — Teresa, Board Ready Beauty

Supply Labeling Rules — Read Before Exam Day

The PSI exam has strict labeling rules. Labeling the wrong items OR failing to label required items can both result in a loss of points.

■ **NO NUMBERS on any labels — ever.** No cheat sheets, no task lists written on containers. Written notes on your supplies = loss of ALL Procedure Criteria points throughout the exam. Identifying a bag by service (e.g. 'facial bag') is allowed.

✓ MUST BE LABELED (in English)	✗ DO NOT LABEL — May Lose Points
30" x 30" kit bag Label: "Pre-sanitized, Clean or Disinfected"	Abrasive/nail files and buffers
Antiseptic / soothing lotion Must be labeled in English	Application brush
Astringent, freshener, or toner Must be labeled in English	Blow dryer
Blood exposure kit / first aid kit Must be labeled in English	Bowl for water (optional)
Cleansing product Must be labeled in English	Clips
Cuticle oil Must be labeled in English	Combs
EPA-approved disinfectant (or simulated) Must be labeled in English	Cotton/cotton pads/sponges/facial tissue
Eye makeup remover Must be labeled in English	Cuticle pusher
Hand sanitizer Must be labeled in English	Dappen dish
Massage product Must be labeled in English	Disposable applicators
Moisturizer Must be labeled in English	Drape(s)
Nail adhesive Must be labeled in English	Electric curling iron
Nail dehydrator / cleanser Must be labeled in English	End papers
Odorless monomer Manufacturer label clearly reading 'odorless' ONLY	Fabric strip

Low odor primer Manufacturer label only — no handwritten labels
Polymer powder Must be labeled in English
Protective cream Must be labeled in English
Simulated perm product e.g., water — must be labeled
Simulated chemical service product e.g., gel or cholesterol — must be labeled
Simulated soft wax product e.g., petroleum jelly or honey — must be labeled
Spray bottle with water Must be labeled in English
Trash bag(s) Must be labeled in English

Foils
Gloves
Hairbrush
Haircutting shears
Head draping
Mannequin hand/finger
Mannequin with stand or tripod
Nail tips
Neck strips
Orangewood stick
Paper towels
Permanent wave rods
Protective cotton
Razor with guard
Tint brush, bowl or bottle
Tip cutter / nail clipper
Towels

Provided by the Exam Venue — Do Not Bring

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Other Key Rules

- **All procedures on mannequins.**
No live models. Mannequin hand must be prepped with tips.
- **Closed-toe shoes required.**
No exceptions — you will not be allowed in without them.

- **No aerosol products.**
Use pump sprays only. Aerosols are not permitted.
- **No cell phones.**
Not allowed in the exam room at all.
- **No trainer hands for nail.**
Use mannequin hand/finger prepped with tips only.
- **No markings on mannequin.**
No writing, coloring, or markings on hair, scalp, or hands.
- **No leaving once signed in.**
You may not leave the exam area once you arrive and sign in.
- **Odorless monomer — examiners check.**
They will verify before the exam begins. Wrong product = zero points for that section.

★ BONUS ★

Printable Supply Labels

Print this page • Cut along the dashed lines • Attach labels to your supplies with tape or a label holder | No numbers allowed. Names only. Manufacturer labels are always acceptable.

30" x 30" Kit Bag Pre-sanitized, Clean or Disinfected boardreadybeauty.com	Antiseptic / Soothing Lotion boardreadybeauty.com	Astringent / Toner boardreadybeauty.com
Blood Exposure Kit First Aid Kit boardreadybeauty.com	Cleansing Product boardreadybeauty.com	Cuticle Oil boardreadybeauty.com
Disinfectant EPA-Approved boardreadybeauty.com	Eye Makeup Remover boardreadybeauty.com	Hand Sanitizer boardreadybeauty.com
Massage Product boardreadybeauty.com	Moisturizer boardreadybeauty.com	Nail Adhesive boardreadybeauty.com
Nail Dehydrator / Cleanser boardreadybeauty.com	Monomer Odorless — Manufacturer Label Only boardreadybeauty.com	Low Odor Primer Manufacturer Label Only boardreadybeauty.com
Polymer Powder boardreadybeauty.com	Protective Cream boardreadybeauty.com	Simulated Perm Solution e.g., Water boardreadybeauty.com
Simulated Chemical Service e.g., Gel or Cholesterol boardreadybeauty.com	Simulated Soft Wax e.g., Petroleum Jelly or Honey boardreadybeauty.com	Spray Bottle Water boardreadybeauty.com
Trash Bag boardreadybeauty.com	Facial Service Bag Optional — identifying bag is allowed boardreadybeauty.com	Nail Service Bag Optional — identifying bag is allowed boardreadybeauty.com

Cut along the dashed lines. Tape or clip each label to its corresponding container. No numbers. No handwritten task steps. Manufacturer labels are always acceptable and preferred where available.